

2000 - 13

COLORADO RARE BIRD REPORT

REDDISH EGRET

Egretta rufescens

Rcd 2/2/01 wpl

7-0 (A)

Location: Lake Cheraw; Cheraw, Otero County, Colorado

Date: September 3, 10 and 17, 2000

I found this bird while birding alone on September 3rd. I also saw it on the 10th and 17th. It was seen by many other birders, including a fairly large group on the CFO field trip that I led that included this site on September 17th.

Lake Cheraw is a large plains reservoir without much shorebird habitat. As far as I know, the Reddish Egret was only seen on the north side of Lake Cheraw. This was only visible from the south shore of the reservoir, which is a distance of probably 1/2 mile. Therefore, the ID of this individual depended much on behavior and comparison to nearby Great Blue Heron. I observed it with my Kowa 20-60X scope. Light conditions varied but viewing conditions were excellent at times. I saw the bird feeding and at rest; never in flight.

Description:

What first drew my attention to this bird was its manner of feeding. It canopy fed, spreading the wings and walking "drunkenly" to and fro. This herky-jerky, unpredictable and staggering feeding style was quite typical of this bird on all days it was observed. I believe that it was a juvenile, as at the distance that I observed it, it was uniform dull gray with a vaguely more reddish neck and head. The bill was either all dark, or at least not strongly bi-colored. The legs were dark. It lacked plumes.

Similar Species:

The Great Blue Heron is much larger, has a white and black pattern on the head and neck, yellow on the bill and dark flight feathers show in flight. This bird was plainer colored, and distinctly smaller and shorter-legged than adjacent Great Blues. The Tricolored Heron has yellow legs and bill, and a white foreneck and undersides. The non-breeding Little Blue Heron is most similar to this bird. The Little Blue Heron has a purplish, not pinkish wash on the head and neck, a distinctly darker tipped bill, greenish-grey legs, proportionately shorter legs (especially the upper leg), and lacks the "dancing" feeding behavior. I believe that the leg proportions of Reddish Egret are different than either Little Blue or Tricolored. Reddish Egret has proportionately longer legs with a longer distance between the body and the first joint ("knee"... but actually "ankle"). This bird had the longer legs of a Reddish Egret.

Experience with Species:

I have seen all mentioned herons, including Reddish Egret in Colorado, California in 1993 and south Texas in March 1994.

This report is prepared from notes made during observation.

Mark Janos
10 Sedum Ct.
Pueblo, CO 81001

Mark Janos